

source DVCS options available at the time. Git has since become the most popular DVCS, and GitHub (a DVCS hosting site that uses Git) immensely increased the ease of collaboration for open source projects.

In fact, Google's Chromium OS is an open source operating system also based on the Linux kernel. Chrome OS, the commercial version of Chromium OS, is packed inside Google's Chromebooks. These netbooks are cheaper than most commercial laptops since they run only a web-thin client (the Chromebook comes with only a web browser and relies almost exclusively on web applications for all its functionality) and now boast of about one-fourth of the market share in the United States for laptops under \$300.



Google Nexus 5 running Android Lollipop

Why OSS?

At the heart of the concept of open source software lie the fundamental ideals of freedom, community service and collaborative effort. It succeeds because the code is being developed and distributed freely and others are encouraged to do the same – with little or no monetary benefit – solely for the genuine desire of making good quality software available to the public.

Where do you begin?

It's advisable to start by looking for OSS alternatives – because there always is one – to any proprietary software you may need. Generally, OSS developers prefer to skimp on feature range in favour of crucial intangibles such as a clean interface, security, stability and good experience in general. So, while you may not have access to some obscure, esoteric features that Photoshop offers, GIMP will probably suffice for your photo editing needs for your next Facebook profile picture.